HELLOLILLY · DEEP-DIVE

Community and the Expertise Exchange

Nobody in the programme should have to solve alone what someone else has already solved.

DEEP-DIVE COMPANION TO VERSION 4

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A companion to the HelloLilly Jobseeker Product Vision, Version 4. Principles and boundaries are in Addendum A.

Opening

Hundreds of jobseekers in the same programme face the same walls. They write the same kinds of letters, look for the same kinds of contacts, freeze at the same interview questions and wonder about the same funding rules, each one alone. Among them are photographers, designers, people who know AI, former lawyers, entrepreneurs, HR people, teachers and tradespeople, whose skills another jobseeker needs this week.

Today none of them can find each other. That is a double loss. Every person reinvents what the person next to them already solved, and the skills sitting idle in the programme are never used, at exactly the time when using them would do the helper as much good as the person helped.

The evidence is clear that this matters. Job clubs, built on peers, structure and accountability, place more people faster than searching alone. Unemployment removes not only income but social contact, purpose and status, and those losses explain part of its harm to mental health. A community that gives contact and purpose back is not a nice extra. It is part of the help.

So HelloLilly treats the other jobseekers as what they are: one of its largest and least used resources. And it builds the community for people who would never join a group for the unemployed: around what they know and do, with the smallest possible first step.

SECTION 01

The Problem

01

- **How it is:** Jobseekers in the same programme never meet. Questions are answered one coach at a time, templates are rewritten by every person, and skills that others need sit unused. And shame keeps people away: few want to be seen in a group defined by being out of work.
- **What is missing:** A place where jobseekers find each other: to ask and answer, to share templates, outreach openers and tutorials, to ask for a connection, and to offer and find expertise.
- **The effect:** Isolation compounds the confidence problem; good solutions never spread; and people who could help each other, and would feel better for it, never do.
- **Scenario:** You need a decent profile photo and someone to look at your portfolio. Three people in your programme are out-of-work photographers, and one is a designer. One of them needs help understanding a contract, and you used to work in HR. None of you will ever know about the others.

SECTION 02

Why People Stay Away

02

The biggest obstacle to a jobseeker community is not technology. It is shame.

- **People manage the shame of unemployment by withdrawing.** In interviews with 80 long-term unemployed people, the shame attached to being out of work led people to pull away from their networks and to distance themselves from other unemployed people. Both cut their networking (Peterie, Ramia, Marston and Patulny, 2019).
- **So a community labelled "for the unemployed" repels the people it is for.** Nobody wants to join a club defined by what they lack.
- **People expect far more refusals than they get.** They expect to need about 50 per cent more requests than they actually do to get a yes (Flynn and Lake, 2008).
- **Asking for advice makes the person asking look more competent, not less** (Brooks, Gino and Schweitzer, 2015).
- **Stigma falls through contact, not information.** Meeting people who have been through the same thing reduces stigma more than facts do (Corrigan and others, 2012, on mental-health stigma, applied here by analogy).
- **Pseudonyms open people up.** On a stigmatised subject, throwaway accounts let people disclose more and drew more engaged support (De Choudhury and De, 2014). Requiring real names has not been shown to reduce harassment, and it tends to hurt the most vulnerable (Matias, The Coral Project, 2017).

The design follows from that. The community is built around what members know and do, not around being out of work. The first step is the smallest possible one: a vote. Experts come to the members, so nobody has to ask. And every member chooses how visible they are.

SECTION 03

The Four Parts

03

PART	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT GIVES
Community (Gemenskap)	Questions and answers, discussions, small wins, and stories of people who got through	Belonging, answers, and proof there is a way through
Shared Bank (Delningsbanken)	Templates, letters, outreach openers, LinkedIn posts, interview answers and tutorials that worked, rated by the people who used them	Nobody starts from a blank page
Expertise Exchange (Kompetensbörsen)	Jobseekers ask for and offer skills	The right skill, from the programme itself
Vouch for Each Other (Gå i god för)	Members who have worked together recommend each other, share contacts and pass on leads	The incubator mechanic: introductions and references

SECTION 04

The Community

04

What it is built around

Rooms by trade and field, not by situation. Logistics and warehouse, care and health, IT and digital, trades and construction, office and administration, and more as members arrive. In a room, people talk about the work: what a good shift handover looks like, which forklift licence employers ask for, what changed in the field this year. Being out of work is a fact in the background, not the topic.

Seeded with things everyone can have an opinion about. The first content in every room is practical and light: polls ("Photo on the CV: yes or no?"), short questionnaires ("Which interview question threw you?"), "rate this opener", the best and the worst job advert of the week. A vote is the smallest possible contribution, so people vote long before they ever post. Results are shown only after voting.

Ask the Expert

A recurring guest slot in each room: a hiring manager, a recruiter, a business owner, a union representative or someone respected in the trade, invited through the coaches' own networks. Members post questions in advance, under their name, their masked name or anonymously, and the guest answers in a scheduled live session and in writing afterwards.

It is networking without having to ask. The expert comes to the members, and every guest is also a warmer contact for the coach who invited them. Guests answer questions; they do not recruit inside the session, and members' details are never passed to them.

Stories from people who were there

Members who got through tell how, honestly and with real timelines. Now and then a well-known person who was once out of work themselves tells their story, because contact with someone who has been there reduces stigma more than any information does. Politicians are not invited: HelloLilly delivers a public service, a political guest would make the community look partisan, and talk would turn to benefits and blame.

Small groups and live sessions, not an open chat

There is no open, real-time chat for everyone. It rewards the confident and needs constant moderation. Instead, members can join a small group of six to eight people who started around the same time, meeting weekly with a coach, which is the job-club format the evidence supports. Live moments are scheduled and hosted. Between them, the rooms run as threads.

What happens there

- **Questions and answers.** "How do you handle the silence after an interview?" "What do you actually write in a LinkedIn post?" "Is 61 too old? Honest answers, please." Answered by peers first, with a coach adding one useful line where it helps.
- **Small wins.** "One reply out of six blind applications" is a success, and is celebrated as one.
- **Stories of getting through.** Told honestly, with real timelines: an offer after fourteen weeks, a tested direction rather than a job yet.

- **Connection requests.** "Does anyone know someone at this company?" "Is anyone else moving from nursing into health tech?"

How it is kept good

The lessons come partly from running a professional community on another platform, where what makes people speak up has been tested:

- **Every important thread has a host.** A coach, or an experienced member, opens it and answers in it. A post nobody answers teaches people not to post.
- **A first answer, fast.** Questions get a first reply within a working day, from a peer or a coach.
- **Masked by default, named by choice.** People verify who they are, then appear under a consistent masked name unless they choose their real name, per room or per post. Only verified programme participants get in, so every member is known to the system and the moderators, and protected from everyone else. Real names come in where they help, in the Expertise Exchange, in vouching and in introductions, and always by choice.
- **Ask anonymously.** Any question can be posted without even the masked name, for the things people would otherwise never ask: age, health, a long gap, a difficult former employer.
- **The house rules at the top of every discussion.** Visible norms shape how people behave, whatever name they use.
- **Correct in the open, credit the person who helped.** When an answer turns out wrong, it is corrected visibly and the person who caught it is thanked.
- **No blame, ever.** Mechanisms, never traits, including in how people describe themselves: "my applications hit the wrong roles" rather than "I am bad at applying". Moderators gently reframe.
- **Coaches participate, sparingly.** Coach posts are rarer than peer posts and never lecture.
- **Nothing medical, nothing legal advice, nothing negative about named employers.** People are pointed to the right professional help instead.

Clear boundaries

LAYER	WHO SEES IT
Public guides and coach-approved resources	Everyone
Community threads	Members, under a masked name by default or a real name by choice
Anonymised examples	Shared only with explicit consent at the point of sharing
Private case data	Only the person and their coach
Coach-only discussions	Coaches

The community is real. The privacy is also real.

SECTION 05

The Shared Bank

05

Why: a template, an opener or an answer that worked for one person should be available to the next.

- **What goes in:** CV and letter templates, outreach openers, LinkedIn posts and comments, interview answers to common questions, short tutorials, checklists, and useful links.
- **Who adds:** jobseekers and coaches. Items from jobseekers are marked as suggested until a coach approves them; anything based on a real person's material is anonymised and shared only with consent.
- **How it is rated:** by the people who used it, and where possible by what happened ("got a reply", "got an interview"), recorded as dated facts, never as guarantees.
- **Where it shows up:** not only in the library, but inside the tools. An opener that worked appears as an option in the Contact Planner, a template in the CV Builder, an answer in the interview war-room, and the right item in the Help right now panel.
- **Contributors are credited**, by name or masked name, as they choose.

SECTION 06

The Expertise Exchange

06

Why: the skills a jobseeker needs this week often sit with another jobseeker in the same programme, and using them is good for both.

How it works

1. **Offer what you know.** A member adds what they can help with: taking a professional photo, reviewing a portfolio, explaining a design or AI tool, reading a business plan, explaining how HR screens applications, practising an interview in a field they know, explaining a trade.
2. **Ask for what you need.** A member posts what they need, or browses the offers.
3. **Match.** The system suggests matches by skill, field, language and location. Both sides agree before anything happens.
4. **A small, time-boxed session.** Typically thirty minutes to an hour, online or in person, with a simple prepared agenda. No money changes hands.
5. **Thank and record.** Both sides say thank you in the system. The helper can choose to add what they did to their own fact bank.

Why helpers benefit too

Helping is not charity. For the helper it is:

- **Evidence of current skill.** "Took professional portfolio photos for six jobseekers" or "reviewed eight CVs from an HR perspective" is true, recent and confirmable, and can go on the CV and LinkedIn profile.
- **Evidence of cooperation.** A session is proof of working with someone else, the kind a CV rarely shows. Once the person confirms it, it goes into their fact bank, ready for an application or the cooperation story in an interview.
- **Structure and purpose** in a week that may have little of either.
- **Practice** in explaining one's expertise, which is exactly what an interview asks for.
- **A network** of people who have seen them work, and who can vouch for them.

The boundaries

- **Help, not professional service.** A former lawyer can explain how a contract usually works; they do not give legal advice or represent anyone. A former nurse can explain a career path; they do not give medical advice.
- **No money, no sales.** The exchange is not a marketplace for paid services.
- **Safety first.** Meetings in public or online; either side can stop at any time; problems can be reported to a coach.
- **Consent and privacy.** Nobody's skills or contact details are shown beyond what they chose to share.

SECTION 07

Vouch for Each Other

07

The mechanic that works so well in startup incubators, built on real interaction:

- **Recommend.** Members who have worked together in the exchange, in a placement, on a course or in a former job can write each other a short recommendation, for a CV reference or LinkedIn.
- **Share contacts.** "I know someone at that company; I can ask if they would talk to you." The introduction is made by the member personally; contacts are never exposed.
- **Pass on leads.** A role that is not right for one member may be perfect for another.
- **With consent at every step.** No one is recommended, introduced or named without agreeing.

SECTION 08

How the Community Connects to the Rest of the Site

08

CONNECTED TOOL	THE CONNECTION
Help right now and Lilly	The right discussion or shared item appears beside the task; Lilly can find it
Tutorial Library and Knowledge Hub	Members suggest clips and resources; coaches approve them
CV Builder and LinkedIn Profile	Templates from the Shared Bank; skills used in the exchange become confirmed facts
Contact Planner and LinkedIn Plan	Openers and posts that worked, offered as options; members as first connections in a new field
Image Studio	A photographer in the exchange for a real portrait session
Interview Preparation and Training	Shared answers; a member from the field to practise with
Learn and Re-skill	Stories of people who made the same move, on the direction and course cards
Placement Finder	Leads passed on by members
Coach Network	Coaches host threads, invite guest experts from their own networks, and step in where a peer answer is not enough
Progress Support	Helping and being helped count as activity, and structure the week
Feedback Loop	Polls and suggestions; results shown only after voting
Outcome Engine	Which shared items and exchanges lead to progress, never below five people per figure

SECTION 09

How It Grows

09

A community is its own product, and an empty one does harm. So it grows in deliberate steps:

STEP	WHAT IT ADDS	WHY IN THIS ORDER
1. The Shared Bank and Tutorial Library	Coach-approved templates, clips and openers	Useful from day one, even with few members
2. Trade rooms, polls and hosted threads	A few rooms by field, seeded with polls, questionnaires and coach-hosted threads on the most common walls	Low-threshold content works with few members; a few lively rooms beat many empty ones
3. Ask the Expert and small groups	Guest experts from the coaches' networks; groups of six to eight	Needs the coaches' contacts and a steady intake
4. The Expertise Exchange	Offers and requests, with simple matching	Needs enough members with varied skills
5. Vouching and leads	Recommendations and shared contacts	Needs relationships built in steps 2 to 4

Whether the community runs on an established community platform adapted to HelloLilly or is built into the system is decided before step 2, and nothing is built before that decision. Demonstration content uses invented personas only and is deleted, never migrated, when real members arrive.

SECTION 10

What Success Looks Like

10

MEASURE	WHY IT MATTERS
First-time posters, and how many began with a vote or an anonymous question	The threshold is low enough
Guest sessions held, and questions asked in them	Networking without having to ask works
Questions answered, and time to first answer	People get help when they ask
Shared items reused, and their dated results	Solutions spread
Exchanges completed, and skills offered	The idle skills in the programme are used
Recommendations and introductions between members	The incubator mechanic works
Members who both help and are helped	The community is mutual, not a help desk
Self-reported sense of not being alone, with consent	The latent losses of unemployment are partly given back

No streaks, no engagement scores, no leaderboard. A good community is measured by what it does for people, not by how much time they spend in it.